Dreamwalk Fungi Forest

SCALING DOWN FOR BIG SOLUTIONS:

THE INNOVATIVE GENIUS OF MICRO PARKS

Written by Thomas Bellows

"Are you from Utah?"

I turned around to face the stranger staring at the blaring Y on my sweatshirt and said, "I'm a student at BYU, so I did come from Utah."

We struck up a casual conversation as we waited for the Rise of the Resistance, a trackless, immersive ride in Disney's Hollywood Studios. I learned that she was from Utah and made frequent trips to Disney World in Orlando.

It's a Small World after all, I guess. The fact that there were two people from Utah standing in line at a theme park in Orlando intrigued me. It prompted me to ask myself questions, such as:

- Would a closer park be a cheaper alternative?
- Would a closer park have more consistent attendance?
- Would a closer park positively impact my local economy?

It is no secret that admission prices to theme parks are rising. According to a study by Mintel done with families in the US, inflation has impacted over 90% of families' leisure and entertainment. Additionally, theme parks such as Disney World or Universal rely on their location to secure guests, but these tourist locations can have fluctuating attendance.

Micro theme parks, which are small-scale themed amusement parks, answer these questions and concerns through:

- **Offering cheaper tickets for admission**
- **Having more consistent attendance**
- **Supporting local economies**

Would Micro Parks be a Cheaper Alternative?

When you look at the costs of operating and maintaining a theme park, micro parks become more enticing than an ice cream Mickey Bar on a hot summer day.

Two professors at Arkansas State University, Desai and Pearlman, indicate that building theme parks in new vacation areas can help avoid large budgets for the maintenance and improvement of old parks, especially in areas of high competition. A small-scale park becomes reasonable as it doesn't require extensive financing for maintenance that you would find within a large park.

Due to inflation, rising admission prices have become a big concern for guests. Figure 1 displays results from a Mintel survey of adults in the United States who had been to a Theme Park within a year. The data suggests that guests feel that the cost of admission would be the top factor in stopping their theme park attendance. Specifically, 60% of guests considered that the price of admission would dissuade them from attending a Theme Park.

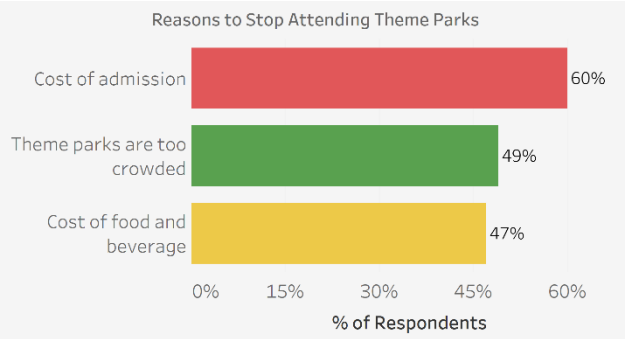

Figure 1. Original Graph by Thomas Bellows. Source data from Mintel.

Micro parks offer a cheaper alternative to theme parks, which these guests want. Additionally, micro parks would bring guests to different locations, which could reduce traffic in current theme parks, which was guests' second biggest concern.

"Micro theme parks appeal to a broader demographic with more budget-friendly ticket prices."

According to Tarah Chieffi, a seasoned theme park and family travel journalist, "Micro theme parks appeal to a broader demographic with more budget-friendly ticket prices." Micro parks fill the market's need for affordable experiences that families of all budgets can enjoy.

Reflecting on my time in line with a fellow Utahn, there isn't a lot of room to attend theme parks often due to their steep price. Micro parks bring theme parks back on the table for a larger audience.

Would Micro Parks Have More Consistent Attendance?

Regional parks that cater to local communities tend to face less variability in attendance. Ady Milman, a professor at the University of Central Florida, suggests that,

> "Regional and local parks, however, are less vulnerable to economic fluctuations due to their protected markets. In spite of the 2008-2010 global economic crises, some regional parks in Europe and North America posted increased attendance."

This demonstrates how a local market, although smaller than parks at a tourist or "destination" center, proves to be more

reliable in terms of attendance and economic profit. This can prove to be very important for park operators as it reduces the inevitable risk that comes with entertainment, as you never know how many guests will come every day.

Guests can commit to micro parks much easier than large theme parks. A great example of this is Dreamwalk, a micro park that uses unique sets to transport you to another world. Speaking of Dreamwalk, David Hiatt, a local radio host, describes how this micro park offers an immersive experience that is affordable, accessible, and doable. Since the park is smaller and less expensive, guests are more likely to visit and revisit the park.

Dreamwalk Galactic Grotto

Families are willing to pay for experiences, but high costs are stopping families from attending theme parks or similar experiences.

Families are willing to pay for experiences, but high costs are stopping families from attending theme parks or attending similar experiences. Figure 2 outlines the results of a study by Mintel of parents with children in the US, which found that over 80 percent of families agree that new experiences are worth paying for. However, many of those families agreed that inflation increased the difficulty of participating in family activities.

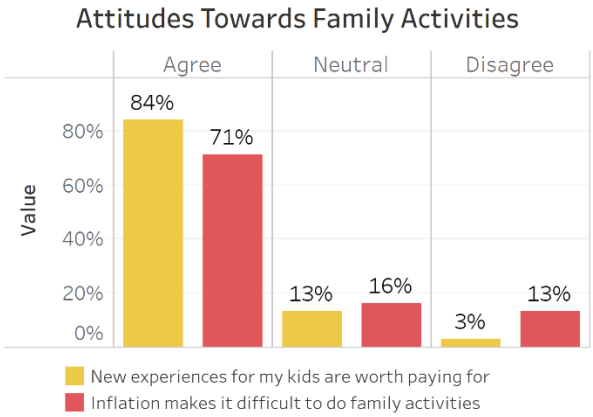

Figure 2. Original Graph by Thomas Bellows. Source data from Mintel.

Parents want to have their children participate in unique experiences, and they need those experiences to be affordable. Micro parks offer an affordable alternative to theme parks, which benefits larger families or budget-friendly families.

Cutting down the cost of travel makes it much easier for guests to commit to a theme park. While the Utahn and I may only make it out to Disneyworld once a year, we could afford to go to a micro park more often and consistently.

Would Micro Parks Positively Impact Local Economies?

Similarly to theme parks, Micro parks contribute to local sustainability. According to the *Worldwide Hospitality and Tourism Themes*, successful theme park development supports local sustainability and provides increased tax revenues and job opportunities. Theme parks, regardless of their size, can help support local governments and residents.

By having more parks across the country, local suppliers and workers can contribute to their local economies. Additionally, this can decrease carbon emissions from having fewer travelers.

These micro parks can not only support economic growth but can also revive economies when built around movie themes. Films can induce people to travel to locations related to a film or to be involved with theme parks related to those films. According to Lázaro Florido-Benítez, a professor at the University of Malaga in Spain,

> "The foremost result of research is that film-induced tourism can be the perfect marketing tool to attract more visitors to theme parks through movies and their real or fictional characters represented in films."

Micro parks could be built around locations where movies are filmed to further appeal to film-induced tourists and give local economies more growth opportunities.

Leisure activities are becoming increasingly common among shopping centers across the world. According to *Women's Wear Daily*, a trade journal focusing on fashion and retail, a real estate trade fair named Mapic has been looking to reinvent shopping centers and integrate leisure activities into these centers. Micro parks can help to reinvent these retail spaces, bringing in greater traffic to shopping centers.

Local businesses are easier for me and fellow Utahns to support, so having more regional micro parks permits more people to support their local parks. Additionally, this helps build a local community of fans around the micro park.

What Now?

Micro parks offer an innovative solution to many of the challenges present in theme parks by:

- **Offering cheaper tickets for admission**
- **Having more consistent attendance**
- **Supporting local economies**

It's a Small World, and that shouldn't stop us from bringing the entertainment closer to fans all over the world.

Developing micro parks can lead to greater economic sustainability and benefit a larger audience. It's a Small World, and that shouldn't stop us from bringing the entertainment closer to fans all over the world.

Micro parks like Dreamwalk are starting to pop up all over the United States, and more will come. Already, things are looking good for my fellow Utahns and me. Get involved with your community and look for opportunities to bring greater entertainment to your hometown.

Endnotes

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AI was used in helping generate ideas for this article, as well as finding some initial sources.

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